

Honesty And Restitution

prc-honesty-and-restitution

Christian Ethics · Integrity · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Truth-telling, integrity in word, and restitution where wrong has been done are required Christian practice.

In plain language

The words used across the anchor verses point in one direction with little room for confusion. In Exodus 20:16 the Hebrew forbids 'answering' (the verb anah, 'to answer or testify') as a 'false witness' (ed sheqer) against a neighbor, built with the negative particle 'no' or 'not' (lo) plus the verb 'to answer or testify' (anah), the same flat prohibitive grammar used for the other commands of the Ten Commandments. Leviticus 19:11, the cross-reference linked from both Pauline passages in the Treasury of Scripture Knowledge (TSK) cross-reference data, chains 'do not steal', 'do not deal falsely' (kachash, 'to deceive'), and 'do not lie' (shaqar) 'one to another', fixing honest speech in the moral law. Wisdom backs it up. Proverbs 12:22 calls 'lips of falsehood' (siphtei sheqer) an abomination to YHWH (the covenant name of God) and Proverbs 19:5 and 19:9 warn the 'false witness' (ed shaqarim) of punishment. The restitution side is just as explicit. Exodus 22 commands the thief to 'repay' (the Hebrew intensive form (piel) of shalem, 'to make whole') fourfold for a stolen sheep and fivefold for an ox. Leviticus 5:23-24 (English 6:1-7) and Numbers 5:6-7 require the offender to 'restore' (heshib, the Hebrew causative form (hiphil) of shub, 'to bring back'), what was taken, add a fifth, and bring the 'guilt offering' (asham), with restitution to the victim coming first and atonement following. The gospel narrative of Luke 19:8 picks up the same restitution vocabulary when Zacchaeus says he 'restores' (apodidomi, 'gives back') fourfold whatever he 'defrauded by false accusation' (sukophanteo) and gives half his goods to the poor, and Jesus answers that salvation has come to this house. The apostolic letters use direct ongoing, simple-statement-of-fact command (present imperative) prohibitive constructions. Ephesians 4:25 uses the participle 'having put off' (apothemenoi) 'the lie' (to pseudos) plus the present imperative 'speak truth' (laleite aletheian), grounded in being members of one body. Colossians 3:9 uses 'do not lie' (me pseudesthe) as a continuous prohibition, grounded in having stripped off the old man. Three patterns line up. Truthful speech is commanded in both Testaments with imperative and prohibition forms. Lying is named as conduct to be put off. Restitution to the wronged neighbor is the legal and narrative remedy and is presented as the fruit of repentance rather than as its price. Narrative texts where deception is reported, such as Rahab or the midwives, describe events without legislating a norm and do not overturn the explicit prohibitions. There is no rival vocabulary in the canon that commends false witness or denies restitution.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0817	אָשָׁם	asham	guilt (offering)	46
H1497	גָּזַל	gazal	to plunder	30

H3584	שָׁחַשׁ	kachash	to deceive	22
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	
H5707	עֵד	ed	witness	69
H6030	אָנָּה	anah	to dwell	315
H7453	רֵעַ	rea	neighbor	186
H7725	שׁוּב	shub	to return	1,057
H7999	שָׁלֵם	shalem	to complete	116
H8266	שָׂקָר	shaqar	to deal	6
H8267	שִׁקְרָה	sheqer	deception	113
G0225	ἀλήθεια	aletheia	truth	110
G0341	ἀνακαινός	anakainoo	to renew	2
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	
G0554	ἀπεκδύομαι	apekduomai	to take off	3
G0591	ἀποδίδωμι	apodidomi	to pay	48
G0659	ἀποτίθημι	apotithemi	to put aside	10
G1504	εἰκών	eikōn	image	
G1922	ἐπίγνωσις	epignōsis	knowledge	
G2195	Ζακχαῖος	Zakchaios	Zacchaeus	3
G2255	ἥμισυς	hemisus	half	5
G3196	μέλος	melos	member	
G3820	παλαιός	palaios	old	
G4139	πλησίον	plēsion	near/neighbor	
G4811	συκοφαντέω	sukophanteo	to extort	2
G5574	ψεύδομαι	pseudomai	to lie	12
G5579	ψεῦδος	pseudos	lie	10

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The pattern of vocabulary is dense and spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical). Explicit bans on false speech stack across the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:16, the word 'no' or 'not' (lo) plus the ongoing or repeated past form (imperfect) of the verb 'to answer or testify' (anah) with the phrase 'false witness' (ed sheqer) in the position of grammatical object), the Holiness Code (Leviticus 19:11, 'do not steal, do not deal falsely' (kachash), 'do not lie one to another' (shaqar)), the wisdom literature (Proverbs 12:22, 'lying lips are an abomination to the LORD' (toebat YHWH siphtei sheqer)), and the apostolic letters (Ephesians 4:25, 'having put off' (apothemenoi) 'the lie' (to pseudos) plus the ongoing, simple statement-of-fact command (present imperative) 'speak truth' (laleite aletheian); Colossians 3:9, 'do not lie' (me pseudesthe) 'to one another'). Explicit verbs for paying back also match. The Hebrew intensive form (piel) shillem ('to make whole, complete') in Exodus 22 and the phrase heshib asham ('he shall restore his guilt-payment') in Leviticus 5:23-24 (Masoretic Text numbering 6:4-5) and Numbers 5:6-7 require returning the stolen good plus one fifth, and Luke 19:8 narrates 'I give back fourfold' (apodidomi tetraploun) as Jesus affirms that salvation has come. The vocabulary forecloses a 'no' reading.

Scripture

Exod.20.16 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8267 שָׁקֵר, H5707 עַד, H7453 רָע, H6030 אָנָּה.

Reasoning. The ninth word of the Ten Commandments forbids 'answering' (H6030 anah, the verb 'to answer or testify') as a 'false witness' (ed sheqer) against a 'neighbor' (rea). The construction is the negative 'no' or 'not' (lo) plus the ongoing or repeated past form (imperfect) of 'to answer' (anah), the same negation-plus-imperfect pattern used for the other absolute, categorical prohibitions (apodictic prohibitions) of the Ten Commandments, which fixes it as a categorical, ongoing ban rather than a contingent rule. The ETCBC syntactic database tags the clause as a 'negative direct quotation' (NQ) with the 'false witness' (ed sheqer) phrase in the position of grammatical object, making truthful testimony a binding covenant obligation.

Lev.19.11 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3584 כָּחַשׁ, H8266 שָׁקֵר.

Reasoning. The Holiness Code chains three prohibitions in a single triad. 'Do not steal', 'do not deal falsely' (kachash, 'to deceive or deny'), and 'do not lie' (shaqar) 'one to a neighbor'. This is the cross-reference cited from both Ephesians 4:25 and Colossians 3:9 in the Treasury of Scripture Knowledge (TSK) cross-reference data, and it anchors the apostolic prohibitions in the Mosaic moral law, demonstrating that the New Testament 'put off' vocabulary is reaching back into this exact verbal triad.

Exod.22.1 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7999 שָׁלֵם.

Reasoning. The theft statute commands the offender to 'repay' (shillem, the Hebrew intensive form (piel) of shalem, 'to make whole, complete') fivefold for a stolen ox and fourfold for a stolen sheep. The intensive (piel) form carries the sense of fully completed compensation rather than partial return. This statute supplies the Mosaic background for the fourfold figure picked up by Zacchaeus in Luke 19:8, an explicit lexical link the Treasury of Scripture Knowledge (TSK) cross-references record.

Lev.6.5 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7999 שָׁלֵם, H0817 אָשָׁם, H1497 תָּזַל.

Reasoning. The trespass-offering statute, which in the Masoretic Text (the standard Hebrew Bible) runs Leviticus 5:20-26 and in the English canon Leviticus 6:1-7, treats lying about a neighbor's deposit, swearing falsely 'to a lie' (sheqer), 'robbery' (gazal), and extortion as covenant offenses requiring real restitution. The offender must 'restore' (shub, 'to bring back, return') what was robbed, 'repay' (shalem) it in full, add 'a fifth' (chamishit) on the day of his 'guilt' (asham, 'guilt or guilt-offering'), and only then bring the ram of 'guilt-offering' (asham) to the priest. The lexical ordering is restitution first, then atonement, which forecloses any reading that treats financial restoration as optional or merely symbolic.

Num.5.7 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7725 שׁוּב, H0817 אָשָׁם.

Reasoning. The Numbers parallel chains 'confession' (yadah, 'to confess or acknowledge') with restoration. He will confess the sin he has done, and he will 'restore' (heshib, the Hebrew causative form (hiphil) of shub, 'to bring back, return') his 'guilt-payment' (asham, his compensation) in full, adding its fifth, and give it to the one to whom he was guilty. The causative form (hiphil) of 'to return' (shub) here means 'to bring back, return, restore', and pairing it with 'guilt-payment' (asham) fixes restitution to the victim as the lexical centerpiece of repentance for wrong done.

Prov.12.22 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H8267 רָשָׁע

Reasoning. The proverb declares 'lips of falsehood' (siphtei sheqer) an 'abomination' (toebah) to YHWH (the covenant name of God), while those who 'deal faithfully' (emunah) are his delight. The two-noun bound phrase (construct chain) pins the moral weight on the type of speech itself, not the social effect, and the wisdom witness joins the legal witness in treating truthful speech as a categorical demand. Proverbs 19:5 and 19:9 reinforce the same 'false witnesses' (ed shaqarim) with the threat of punishment.

Eph.4.25 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0659 ἀποτίθημι, G0225 ἀλήθεια, G5579 ψεῦδος, G3196 μέλος, G4139 πλησίον

Reasoning. The completed-past middle participle 'having put off' (apothemenoi, aorist middle participle, 'a completed past action in the middle voice where the subject acts on itself') 'the lie' (to pseudos) governs the ongoing, simple-statement-of-fact command (present imperative) 'speak truth' (laleite aletheian), pairing a decisive break with falsehood and an ongoing practice of speaking truth with the 'neighbor' (plesion). The grounding clause, 'because we are members' (mele) 'one of another', ties truth-telling to the integrity of the body. The verb 'to put off' (apotithemi) is the same 'put off' vocabulary used elsewhere for laying aside garments and the old conduct (Hebrews 12:1, James 1:21).

Col.3.9 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5574 ψεύδομαι, G0554 ἀπεκδύομαι, G3820 παλαιός, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Reasoning. The prohibition 'do not lie' (me pseudesthe) 'to one another' (eis allelous) is an ongoing, simple-statement-of-fact command (present imperative) with the negative 'not' (me), which targets the ongoing practice of lying as such and not merely a single act. It is grounded on the completed-past middle participle 'having stripped off' (apekdusamenoi), 'having stripped off the old man with its practices' (praxesin). The 'stripping off' verb (apekduomai) is a strengthened form of the 'put off' vocabulary, framing truthful speech as the visible mark of renewed identity rather than an optional addition.

Col.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0341 ἀνακαινώνω, G1922 ἐπίγνωσις, G1504 εἰκών

Reasoning. The new man is 'being renewed' (anakainoumenon, ongoing present-tense passive participle, 'an ongoing action done to the subject') in 'knowledge' (epignosis, 'full or accurate knowledge') after the 'image' (eikon) of its Creator. The continuous renewal supplies the positive counterpart to the prohibition against lying in verse 9, locating honest conduct within ongoing conformity to the Creator and recalling the 'image of God' language of Genesis 1:26.

Luke.19.8 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2195 Ζακχαῖος, G0591 ἀποδίδωμι, G4811 συκοφαντέω, G2255 ἥμισυς

Reasoning. Zacchaeus (Zakchaios) declares he gives 'half' (hemisia) of his goods to the poor and, where he has 'defrauded by false accusation' (esukophantesa, a completed past action of sukophanteo, a word found only here and Luke 3:14, making it a near-hapax, a word that occurs only twice in the entire New Testament), he 'restores' (apodidomi, 'gives back') 'fourfold' (tetraploun). The narrative joins confession of dishonest gain with concrete restitution exceeding the Mosaic minimum of fourfold for a sheep, and Jesus pronounces salvation come to the house. The lexical force of 'I give back fourfold' (apodidomi tetraploun) is restitution regardless of whether the ongoing, simple-statement-of-fact verbs (present-tense verbs) are read as habitual or as a vow.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Luke.19.8	Exod.22.1	tsk	1
Eph.4.25	Lev.19.11	tsk	1

Col.3.9	Lev.19.11	tsk	1
Eph.4.25	Eph.4.15	tsk	1
Exod.20.16	Exod.23.6	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Ezek.11.19	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Col.3.12	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Ps.51.10	tsk	1
Luke.19.8	Luke.3.14	tsk	1
Luke.19.8	Luke.3.8	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Josh.2.4-6 · addressed

Rahab's concealment of the spies and the midwives' speech in Exodus 1:19 are narrated descriptively. The commendations in Hebrews 11:31 and James 2:25 are anchored on 'faith' (pistis) and on receiving the messengers, not on the false speech itself. The texts narrate without legislating, so they do not establish a competing norm against the explicit prohibitive constructions of Exodus 20:16 ('no' or 'not' (lo) plus the ongoing or repeated past form (imperfect) of 'to answer' (anah)), Leviticus 19:11 ('do not lie' (shaqar)), Ephesians 4:25 ('having put off' (apothemenoi) 'the lie' (to pseudos)), and Colossians 3:9 ('do not lie' (me pseudesthe), an ongoing, simple-statement-of-fact command (present imperative)). The proposition concerns required practice, which the imperatives establish directly.

1Sam.16.2 · addressed

YHWH (the covenant name of God) instructs Samuel to bring a heifer and say he has come to sacrifice, concealing the anointing of David from Saul. The instruction does not include 'lie' (shaqar) or 'falsehood' (sheqer) vocabulary, and the cover statement is materially true. Samuel does in fact sacrifice. The text reports a strategic non-disclosure, not the 'false witness' (ed sheqer) that Exodus 20:16 prohibits. The lexical category of the Ten Commandments prohibition, false testimony injurious to a neighbor, is not engaged.

1Kgs.22.22 · addressed

The 'lying spirit' (ruach sheqer) in the mouth of Ahab's prophets is narrated as a judicial act of God against Ahab, not as a prescriptive norm. The vocabulary here borrows the same 'falsehood' (sheqer) root, but the text frames it as a sentence on a king who has rejected the truthful prophet Micaiah. It does not commend lying for humans. The Ten Commandments and the apostolic imperatives remain the prescriptive layer.

Luke.19.8 · addressed

Zacchaeus speaks in the ongoing, simple-statement-of-fact tense (present tense: 'I give' (didomi), 'I give back' (apodidomi)), which some read as describing his existing habit rather than a new vow. Either reading supports the proposition, because in both cases honest restitution is the conduct Jesus affirms as evidence that salvation has come to the house. The lexical force of 'I give back fourfold' (apodidomi tetraploun), 'give back fourfold', is restitution regardless of the temporal nuance.

Concordance traversed

G0225, G0659, G0591, G5579, G5574, G4811, G2195, G2255, G0554, G0341, H8267, H8266, H5707, H7453, H6030, H7999, H7725, H0817, H1497, H3584, H3808

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

luke-19-8-word-order at Luke.19.8: impact none. The SBLGNT (SBL Greek New Testament) apparatus marks word-order and minor lexical variation in the clause about giving half to the poor and restoring fourfold, but every witness retains both the giving to the poor and the 'I give back fourfold' (apodidomi tetraploun) restitution. The verdict on restitution holds across all readings.

The anchor verses span Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Proverbs, Luke, Ephesians, and Colossians, none of which falls within the open-cbqm (an open project for the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) 3 John published scope. The bundle reports 'not_in_ecm_scope' (not in the published critical-edition scope) true and supplies no material variant units.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology, dispensationalism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the Ten Commandments and Holiness Code prohibitions on false witness and lying as the abiding moral law of the one covenant of grace, carried forward into the apostolic imperatives of Ephesians 4:25 and Colossians 3:9. The Mosaic restitution statutes of Exodus 22, Leviticus 6, and Numbers 5 are read as case-law applications of the same moral principle, so restitution remains binding equity for the church.

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Locates the requirement in the renewed 'new man' identity of Colossians 3:10 and the one-body grounding of Ephesians 4:25, where truthful speech and restitution flow from union with Christ and regeneration rather than from the Mosaic code as such. The verdict is the same because the apostolic imperatives use direct prohibitive constructions ('do not lie' (me pseudesthe), 'having put off' (apothemenoi) 'the lie' (to pseudos)) that are independent of the Mosaic citation.

dispensationalism: affirms · Treats the Mosaic restitution statutes as covenantally bound to Israel under the Sinai administration, but reads the New Testament imperatives in Ephesians 4:25 and Colossians 3:9 as direct commands to the church grounded in the new identity in Christ. Truth-telling and the restitution example of Luke 19:8 (affirmed by Jesus) remain required Christian practice in the present dispensation.

All three lenses reach the same verdict because the New Testament imperatives are explicit and lexically independent of the Mosaic citation chain, and the gospel narrative of Luke 19 attaches restitution to a verdict of salvation. The lenses differ on the path, not the result.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem speaks of truth-telling, integrity in word, and restitution as required Christian practice. The terms are descriptive of conduct, not loaded with a tradition-specific taxonomy or a contested verdict-assuming phrase, so no neutralization was required. The verdict is derived from the lexical pattern of the cited anchors. Direct lexical queries against the lexical store confirmed canon counts ('falsehood' (sheqer) 113 distinct verses, 'witness' (ed) 69, 'neighbor' (rea) 186, 'to answer or testify' (anah) 315, 'to make whole, complete' (shalem) 116, 'to return' (shub) 1057, 'guilt or guilt-offering' (asham) 46, 'to rob' (gazal) 30, 'to deceive' (kachash) 22, 'lie' (pseudos) 10, 'to lie' (pseudomai) 12, 'to give back' (apodidomi) 48, 'to defraud by false accusation' (sukophanteo) 2) and the verse-level token presence of the cited dictionary forms (lemmas) in Exodus 20:16, Leviticus 19:11, Exodus 22:1-4, Leviticus 5:23-24 (English 6:1-7), Numbers 5:6-7, Proverbs 12:22, Ephesians 4:25, Colossians 3:9-10, and Luke 19:8.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.16
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Exod.20.16
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7999
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0817
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8267

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0591
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5579
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5574
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.4.25
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.3.9
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Luke.19.8
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Lev.6.5
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Num.5.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.19.8
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.4.25
morphology	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Luke.19.8

License audit

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SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

(none)